

Character Annotation Guidelines

Version 2.0

Objective

The general aim of this annotation work is to detect information about the characters in stories. These guidelines are based on the German version designed by the LitBERT project¹. Both these projects aim to improve the ability of language models to detect information about characters in literary texts.

For the annotation tasks, we briefly define characters as follows:

A **character** is a mental representation by a reader. In its minimal structure, a character can display intentional actions and communication; it can also be presented as having mental states, desire, beliefs, emotions, and possessing both an outer aspect (appearance) and inner aspect (psychology).

There are in total two annotation tasks:

1. identify the mentions of fictional characters;
2. annotate the coreference of character mentions.

These annotations can be used in subsequent work to both evaluate the ability of language models and serve as training material for future language models.

We use INCEpTION² as the annotation tool. A detailed User Guide for INCEpTION is available online³.

Practical notes for annotation in INCEpTION are highlighted in these red boxes.

¹ <https://www.informatik.uni-wuerzburg.de/datascience/projects/nlp/litbert/>

² <https://inception-project.github.io/>

³ <https://inception-project.github.io/releases/34.1/docs/user-guide.html>

Task 1: Character Mentions Annotation

1.1 Introduction

The **annotation of a character** is *not* always realized in a straightforward way through the naming of the corresponding character but more extensively through mention of the character via proper name, pronoun, social role, periphrasis, or other ways of referring to it. In practice, the annotation will assign the tag CharacterMention to all these referential units, by selecting the appropriate span. Then, an additional (ideally uniform) character name is added as an attribute to this annotation.

Once a mention is annotated with a CharacterMention, other annotation units can refer to the same character by using the same CharacterMention label. In the case of mentions referring to multiple characters (e.g., plural “they”), a new CharacterMention label must be created, listing all relevant character names (e.g., “Batman+Robin”).

The text input box in INCEpTION can remember the previous input, so if the same character appears repeatedly, no need to manually spell the full name every time.

1.2 Annotation of Character Mentions

More specifically, we consider these following types of mentions:

- **Proper names**, such as *Steve, Steve Rogers, Rogers*
- **Pronouns**: Personal (*I, you, he, she, they*), possessive (*his, her, their*), demonstrative (*this, that, these, those*), reflexive (*himself, herself, themselves*), and indefinite pronouns (*someone, anybody*), provided they refer to an identifiable entity.
- Specific **Noun phrases**: Definite or possessive noun phrases that denote a specific individual, e.g., *her sister, his brother*.
- **Generics**, such as *baker, mother, men, count, court councilor, walker, idiot, beauty, the travel group*.
- **Combinations of generics and proper names**, such as *court councilor James, Mrs. James, Doctor Haggard, Uncle Bill, Sister Tanja*.
- **Metonymical uses**, such as in “*three pairs of eyes* watched the event unfold” (referring to people observing the event). However, it is worthy noting that examples like “one hand patted his back”, “footsteps were heard”, are interpreted literally so should NOT be annotated. The principle is: if the expression clearly refers to a character, it should be annotated. However, if it only hints at a character’s presence through attributes like clothes or body parts, it should NOT be annotated.
- **Zero pronouns**: In Spanish, Italian, and other pro-drop languages, subject/object pronouns are often grammatically omitted but remain implied by context, such as “Cerro la puerta” ([He] closed the door).

Relevant mentions are annotated by marking them in the text with the tag CharacterMention in the **Character Mention** layer, and complemented with the additional attribute Character Name. If the full name of the character appears in the text (GivenName FamilyName), use the full name. If only part of it appears (GivenName, Nickname, or FamilyName), fill in the most recognizable name. If it is a first-person or second-person narrative, and there is no information suggesting the character's name, fill in the corresponding personal pronoun, “I” or “You”.

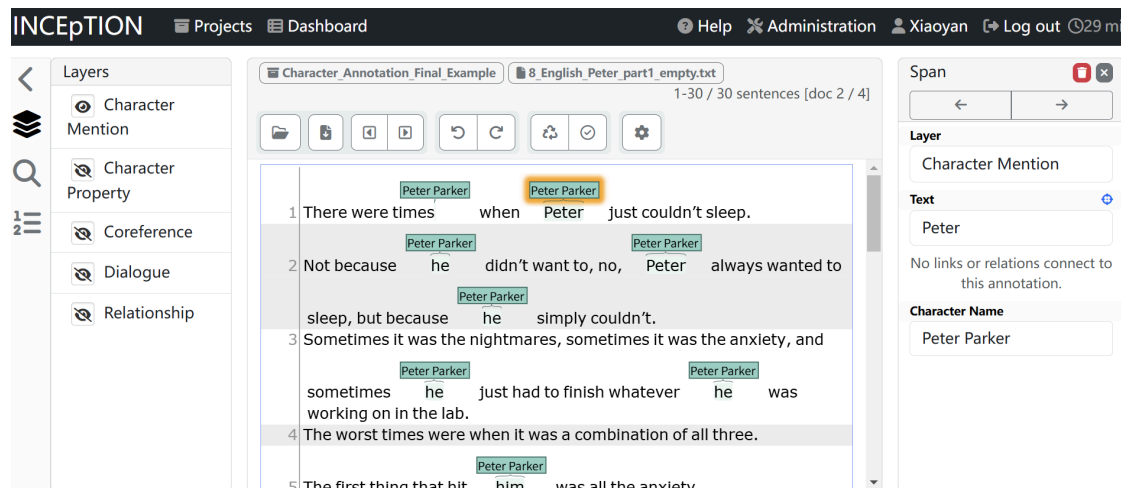


Figure 1 (a). Example of Character Mention Annotation in INCEpTION

1.2.1 For Noun Phrases, include modifiers (e.g., prepositional phrases, relative clauses) if they are integral to identifying the referent:

- When handling prepositional phrases:

Example (1a): *The man in the room* laughed.

Observation: Include "in the room" as part of the mention.

Annotation result: The span of "The man in the room" annotated with the tag CharacterMention.

Example (1b): *This kind hunter* got a warm welcome.

Annotation result: The span of "This kind hunter" annotated with the tag CharacterMention.

Example (1c): *A lady with a red hat beside the window* laughed.

Annotation result: The span of "A lady with a red hat beside the window" annotated with the tag CharacterMention.

- **When handling relative clauses:**
 - If the relative clause is adjacent to the noun phrase, include it in the span.
 - If the relative clause is non-adjacent, exclude the relative clause (INCEpTION does not allow discontinuous span). See this example:

Example (2a): *The man who stole the bicycle* got caught last week.

Observation: This is an example of an adjacent relative clause.

Annotation result: The span of "The man who stole the bicycle" is annotated with the tag CharacterMention.

Example (2b): *A man* entered the room who had stolen my bicycle.

Observation: This is an example of a non-adjacent relative clause.

Annotation result: The span of "A man" is annotated with the tag CharacterMention.

1.2.2 For Nominal Predicates, both proper name and nominal predicate need to be annotated as CharacterMention.

Example (2c): *John* is a *carpenter*.

Observation: This is an example of nominal predicate: “a carpenter” is the nominal predicate.

Annotation result: The spans of “John” and “a carpenter” are annotated with the tag CharacterMention.

1.2.3 For characters that do not have a specific name, still annotate them as CharacterMention and input a description as **Character Name**.

It is necessary to annotate *all* mentions of the characters, even though they are not the main characters.

For example, in dialogues where pronouns like “you” are frequently used, it is crucial to carefully analyze the context to determine the correct referent. The annotation should reflect the intended meaning and the relationships between characters as presented in the text.

Example (3): Emily noticed how tidy the house was and commented, “Mom, *you* look so happy here.” Paula smiled and replied, “It’s just easier to keep things in order when *you* live alone.”

Observation: When annotating pronouns like “you” in dialogues, it is essential to identify the referent based on the context. In this case, the first “you” refers to Paula, who is addressed as “Mom”, the second “you” is a generic pronoun referring to people who live alone.

Annotation result: The first “you” from “Mom, you look so happy here.” is annotated with the tag CharacterMention and the additional attribute **Character Name** with the value “Paula”. The second “you” from “It’s just easier to keep things in order when you live alone.” is annotated with the tag CharacterMention and the additional attribute **Character Name** with the value “people live alone”.

1.2.4 For plural pronouns like “classmates of him”, “the whole team”, these should be annotated as CharacterMention and input a consistent description as **Character Name** if they appear multiple times. There is also a very common case called “split antecedents”, for example when “they” refers to previously mentioned characters A, B, and C. In this case, “they” should also be annotated as **ONE** independent CharacterMention with the **Character Name** being “A+B+C”. There is no need to annotate this one span three times to refer to different characters. The linking of “they” as referring to “A”, “B”, and “C” is done using the **Relationship** Layer, by drawing a relationship from “they” to the specific characters included in it (see Figure 1b below).

In summary, in the CharacterMention layer, you can specify **one time** that this plural pronoun “them” refers to several specific characters via Relationship linking, then later when we process the coreference, all the repeated “them” referring to these characters would be linked together as one coreference chain. Note that you should **NOT** connect two plural pronouns together, the inclusion relationship should be always from one plural pronoun to multiple specific characters.

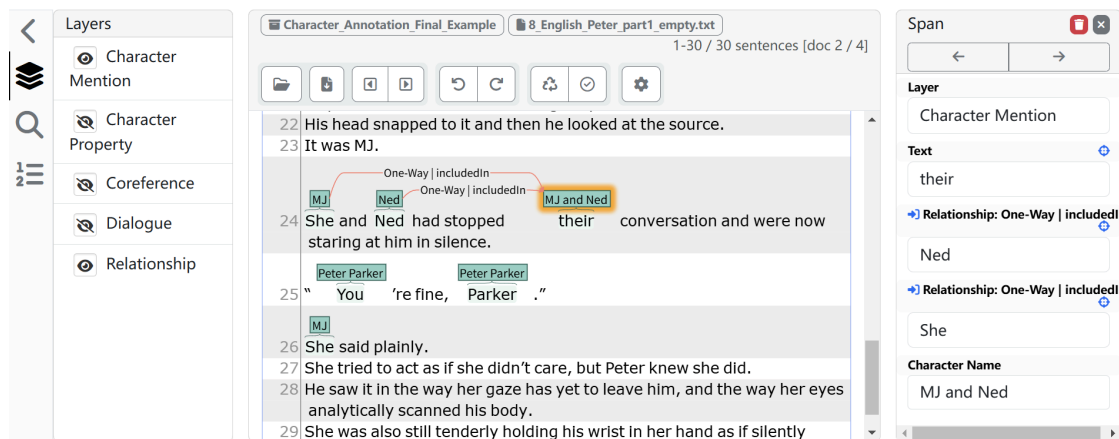


Figure 1 (b). Example of Plural Character Mention Annotation in INCEpTION

In INCEpTION, you can create this relationship between plural character mention and specific character mention by **first selecting the plural mention**. In figure 1b select “their” **and then move the mouse to one specific character mention**—for example, “Ned”—then right click and a button “link to” will appear. Click this button and you will see that one relationship will be created.

As figure 1c shows, you need to choose the Direction (usually “One-Way”) and then select “include” as “Inclusion Relation Type”. “Social Relation Type” here is usually left empty for this task.

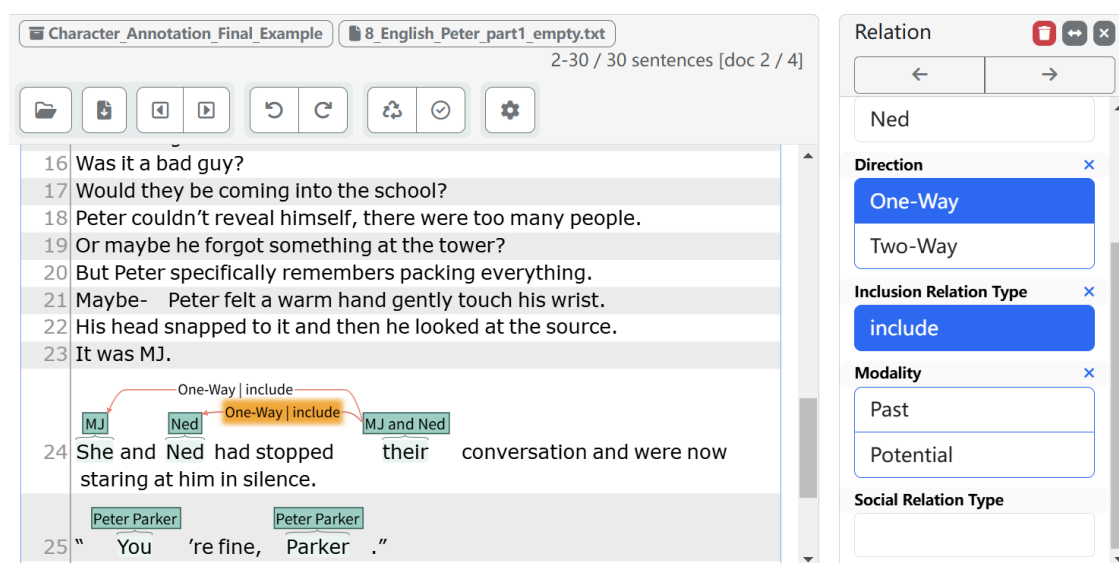


Figure 1 (c). Example of Plural Character Mention Annotation in INCEpTION

Note: There could be overlaps between span CharacterMentions. For example, when “they” refers to the previously mentioned character A and character B, “they” needs to be annotated twice, once linking it to character A and once linking it to character B.

Example (4): “You met Paula before, this is *her daughter*, Emily.”

Observation: “Paula” and “Emily” are easy to annotate, but the expression “her daughter” is an example of the above-mentioned “Specific noun phrases” and contains two mentions: the first one is “her daughter”, which should be annotated using “Emily”

as **Character Name**; the second one is “her”, which is a mention of “Paula”, therefore you should also annotate “her” linking it to “Paula”.

Annotation result: The spans “Paula” and “her” are annotated as **CharacterMentions** with the **Character Name** being “Paula”. The spans “her daughter” and “Emily” are annotated as **CharacterMentions** with the **Character Name** being “Emily”.

1.2.5 For Zero pronouns

To create a zero-length annotation, hold Shift and click on the position where you wish to create the annotation.

Always place the zero-width span immediately after the syntactically governing token (typically the final verb or the punctuation mark following it). This “right-edge” principle ensures consistent coreference resolution across pro-drop languages. See the following examples:

Example (5a) [Spanish]: “Carlos compró pan. Comió[Ø] en el parque.” (Carlos bought bread. [He] ate in the park.)

Observation: There is an omitted subject [Ø] in the second sentence that refers unambiguously to “Carlos”. The zero pronoun [Ø] is governed by the finite verb “Comió” (ate).

Annotation result: Insert zero-width span [Ø] at “Comió[Ø] en el parque.” place, annotated as **CharacterMentions** with the **Character Name** being “Carlos”.

Example (5b) [Bahasa Indonesia]: “Dia membaca bukunya[Ø] sambil minum kopi.” (He read his book while drinking coffee.)

Observation: The possessive suffix “-nya” (his/her) is a merged zero pronoun, referring to the subject “Dia” (He).

Annotation result: Insert a zero-width span [Ø] at “Dia membaca bukunya[Ø] sambil minum kopi” after the relevant token, annotated as **CharacterMention** with the same **Character Name** used for “Dia”.

Note: You only need to annotate Zero pronoun when a complete sentence (marked with period) does not have a subject, if only in a part of sentence (marked with comma), for example: I arrived at the office, [Ø] found that nobody was there), you don’t need to annotate a zero pronoun after the word “found”.

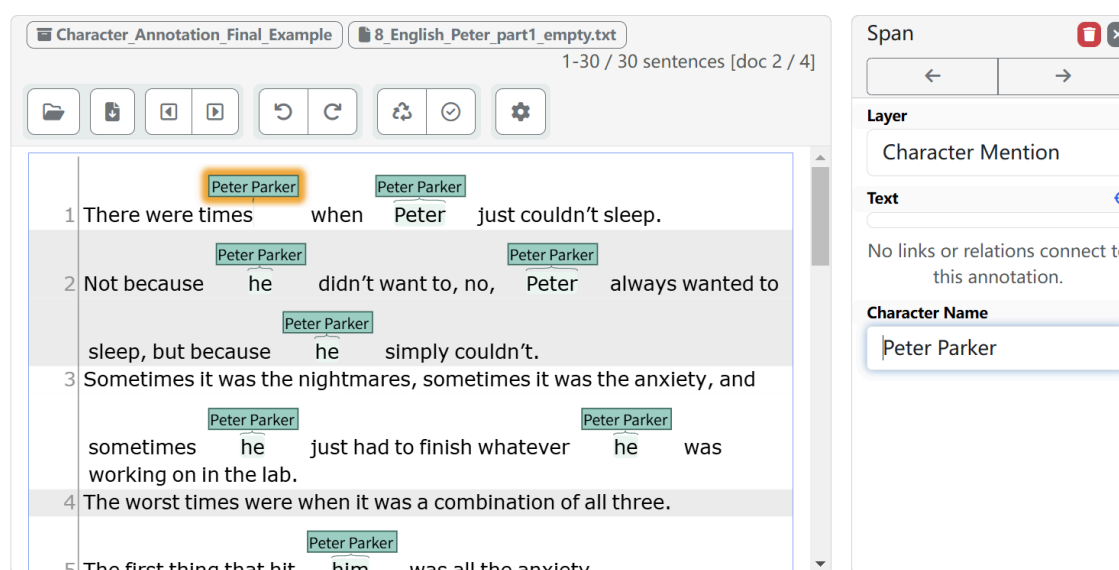


Figure 1 (d). Example of how to annotate Zero-width Character Mention (the example in English is only for illustrative purpose, not grammatically correct).

1.3 Annotation of Character Coreference

To ensure that all mentions referring to the same character are linked together, please make sure that you give a consistent Character Name to all the [CharacterMention](#) of one unique character. For plural mentions, you also need to keep consistency. For example, if the Character Name is “A and B”, then you need to reuse exactly the same Character Name for other [CharacterMentions](#) that refer to the same group of characters.

It is good to follow the rules here defined for coreference resolution to check the previous annotation of [CharacterMentions](#).

1.3.1 Here are some common cases that should be annotated as coreference. Do not annotate coreference between a proper name and a nominal predicate (e.g., “John is a carpenter”). The predicate nominal is a [CharacterMention](#), but also a descriptive statement.

Example (6a): *John, the painter, sold his first work.*

Observation: When annotating appositions, you need to identify the coreference relationship between the main noun and the apposition. In this case, “John” is the main noun, and “the painter” is the apposition. Additionally, the possessive pronoun “his” also refers to John.

Annotation result:

- “John” is annotated with the tag [CharacterMention](#) and the additional attribute [Character Name](#) with the value “John”.
- “the painter” is annotated with the tag [CharacterMention](#) and the additional attribute [Character Name](#) with the value “John”. If there is a relative pronoun “who” like “John, who is the painter”, the “the painter” in this span together should also be annotated with the tag [CharacterMention](#).
- “his” is annotated with the tag [CharacterMention](#) and the additional attribute [Character Name](#) with the value “John”.

In this way, we can create coreference chain by linking “John”, “the painter”, “his” together after the annotation finishes.

Example (6b): *X is the one who won the first prize.*

Observation: This is a case of a predicate nominal construction (“X is the one”) followed by an adjacent relative clause (“who did...”). The relative clause is directly modifying “the one” and provides additional information about the character.

Annotation result:

- “X” is annotated with the tag CharacterMention and the additional attribute **Character Name** with the value “X”.
- “the one who won the first prize” is annotated with the tag CharacterMention and the additional attribute **Character Name** with the value “X”.
- Coreference links are created between “X” and “the one who won the first prize”.

1.3.2 Here are some common cases that **Should NOT** be annotated as coreference:

Negation and Hypotheticals: For CharacterMention and Coreference, we focus exclusively on whether a character exists as part of the story world. The key principle is: existence in the story world determines annotation, not grammatical negation or hypothetical phrasing.

Key Rules:

- Negation: If a character exists in the narrative world, annotate all mentions regardless of negation. Negation only affects descriptive properties, not character existence.
- Hypotheticals: 1) Annotate characters that exist in the actual narrative world, even when mentioned in hypothetical contexts. 2) Do not annotate purely generic, imaginary, or metaphorical references that don't correspond to actual story characters. 3) Coreference: Establish coreference links only between mentions that refer to the same entity within the actual narrative world.

See the following examples:

Example (6c1): But, whose kid wouldn't bug their eyes out if [they] saw [their own] dad relaxedly sitting in his briefs in his own working space, complete with sunglasses while sipping fruit punch on his hand?

Observation: This statement refers to an event actually happening in the story world, with both the dad and kid actually existing and doing what is stated. It is a rhetorical hypothetical question, even if inspired by real events. “whose kid”, “dad”, and the related pronouns are generic constructs, not references to specific characters in the story world. The phrasing (“whose kid,” “their dad”) invites the reader to imagine a scenario, but does not point to established story entities.

Annotations: No annotation.

Example (6c2): “*Those kids* would bug *their* eyes out if [they] saw [their own] *dad* relaxedly sitting in *his* briefs in *his* own working space, complete with sunglasses while sipping fruit punch on *his* hand.”

Observation: This statement refers to an event actually happening in the story world, with both the dad and kid actually existing and doing what is stated. The characters (“kid”, “dad”) exist in the story world. CharacterMention and Coreference annotation applies, because they refer to real entities. The action's occurrence does not impact annotation: [they] and [their own] do not need to be annotated as zero-width pronouns since there are already subjects like “kid” appearing in this sentence.

Annotations:

- “those kids” → Tagged as CharacterMention. CharacterName could be “Character A and B” or “A+B”. It is also a plural pronoun. If this is the first time this plural pronoun appears, use Relationship Inclusion to specify that it refers to Character A (CharacterMention) and Character B (CharacterMention) respectively. Later you don’t need to repeat this inclusion linking step, if this plural character mention appears again. But make sure to keep the Character Name consistent!
- “their” → Tagged as CharacterMention. Coreference with “those kids”.
- “dad” → Tagged as CharacterMention. Coreference with “whose”. It is also a plural pronoun, similar to previous steps. If there are two specific characters mentioned before as Character A’s dad and B’s dad, this plural pronoun’s CharacterName could be “Dad of Character A and B”.
- All three “his” → Tagged as CharacterMention. Coreference with “those kids”.

Example (6d): *She* behaved oddly compared to other students, *she* didn't look like a listener.

Observation: The female character (“she”) exists in the story, so both mentions are annotated. The negation (“didn’t look like a listener”) is descriptive, not existential.

Annotations:

- “She” → Tagged as CharacterMention with attribute Character Name (if known).
- “she” → Tagged as CharacterMention and coreferent with the first “She.”

Example (6e): *He* is not a *teenager*.

Observation:

This is a negation of a subject-predicate nominal structure. According to the guidelines, both the subject and the predicate nominal should be annotated as CharacterMentions. However, since the sentence is negated, the two mentions are not coreferent. Therefore, the subject and the predicate nominal are annotated separately without establishing a coreference link between them.

Annotations:

- “He” → Tagged as CharacterMention with attribute Character Name (if known).
- “a teenager” → Tagged as CharacterMention with attribute Character Name “a teenager”.

Example (6f): *Eduardo* stood by the door, folding *his* arms, watching *Mark* dash around like a wind-up toy while *he* waited for *the babysitter* to put the toys away.

Observation:

Expressions such as “a wind-up toy” and “the babysitter” are used here as hypothetical or metaphorical references. In such cases, we annotate the actual entities (the targets of the metaphor) as CharacterMentions, but do not annotate the metaphorical or hypothetical references themselves.

Annotations:

- “Eduardo” → Tagged as CharacterMention with attribute Character Name “Eduardo”.
- “Mark” → Tagged as CharacterMention with attribute Character Name “Mark”.

Example (6g): In *my* imagination, *my husband* is a brave and strong soldier.

Observation:

This sentence describes a hypothetical or imaginary scenario. When a character is evoked in such an unreal context, all relevant mentions are annotated as CharacterMentions. However, since the scenario is not real, no coreference links are established between these mentions.

Annotations:

- “my” → Tagged as CharacterMention with attribute Character Name (if known).
- “my husband” → Tagged as CharacterMention with attribute Character Name (if known).
- “a brave and strong soldier” → Tagged as CharacterMention with attribute Character Name “a soldier”.